WOLFE

BY DORIAN WOLFE

STARTER GUIDE · FOR HER · USA · CANADA · UK

DATING AGAIN AFTER 35 FOR WOMEN

A calm, safety-first plan for starting again after divorce, loss or a long time single. One small action in every chapter.

DORIAN WOLFE · AI-GENERATED CHARACTER

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Dorian Wolfe is an AI-generated character, not a real person, and has no personal life story. This is general communication advice for adults. It is not therapy, medical, legal or financial advice, and no result is guaranteed. Always respect other people's boundaries and consent.

START HERE

YOU ARE NOT BEHIND

You may have been married for years, raising children, caring for parents, building a career, or simply busy. Now you want to meet someone again, and it feels like everyone else already knows how. They do not. Most people feel rusty.

No clock	There is no correct age or timetable for starting again.
No performance	You are not auditioning. You are deciding whether you enjoy someone.
Safety first	Your comfort and safety come before politeness, always.
Small steps	Each chapter ends with one small thing to try.

A NOTE ON EVIDENCE

This guide uses general relationship, safety and social-skills advice plus common sense. There is little research on dating after 35, and almost none on conversations at this age, so treat everything as practical guidance, not a guarantee. Dorian Wolfe is an AI-generated character with no personal story.

CHECK IN

ARE YOU READY? A QUICK CHECK

There is no test you must pass. These questions only help you notice where you are.

- [ ] I can talk about my past without feeling overwhelmed most of the time.
- [ ] I want company or a relationship, not only to fill a silence.
- [ ] I have people I can talk to if a date goes badly.
- [ ] I have time and energy to meet someone this month, even once.
- [ ] I know my basic limits: what I will and will not do.

If you tick fewer than three, nothing is wrong. You may want more time, or some support first. See the support chapter near the end.

IF IT FEELS HEAVIER THAN NERVES

If you feel hopeless, or think about harming yourself, please talk to someone now. USA and Canada: call or text 988. UK: Samaritans 116 123. Emergency: 911 (USA, Canada) or 999 (UK).

GRIEF, PACE AND EXPECTATIONS

After a divorce or the death of a partner, mixed feelings are normal: relief, guilt, anger, excitement, sadness, sometimes in the same hour. Research on recovery shows wide differences between people, so there is no right amount of time to wait.

Name it	Write down what you feel today. One line is enough.
Set your pace	Decide how fast you want to go. "Slowly" is allowed.
Keep your friends	A new person should add to your life, not replace it.
Expect bumps	Some dates will be dull. Some will be nice and go nowhere. That is normal.

TRY THIS

Complete this sentence: "In six months, I would like dating to feel ..." Keep the answer on your phone.

FOUNDATIONS

REBUILD YOUR CIRCLE FIRST

People who have friends and activities do better at everything, including dating. A full week makes dating a nice extra, not a rescue.

- [ ] Message one friend and make a plan.
- [ ] Join one class, group or club (walking, books, choir, volunteering).
- [ ] Say yes to one invitation you would usually turn down.
- [ ] Tell one trusted person you are thinking of dating again.

WHY IT MATTERS

You will want someone to call before and after a date. Pick that person now.

YOUR STORY IN 30 SECONDS

You will be asked "So, tell me about yourself" often. A short, warm answer makes it easier.

Who you are	Your work or what fills your days, in one line.
What you enjoy	Two specific things (a walk by the river, baking, live music).
What you are looking for	One honest sentence.

> **I run a small bakery and spend weekends walking the dog by the river. I am back to meeting people after a few quiet years, and I am looking for something real, taken slowly.**
>
> For example only. Use your own words.

WRITE YOURS

THE PAST

TALKING ABOUT YOUR EX, YOUR KIDS, YOUR LOSS

Say a short, honest line early. Save the long story for when you trust the person.

Ex-partner	"I was married for fourteen years. It ended two years ago and I am in a good place." Then move on.
Late partner	"I am widowed. I will mention him or her sometimes. That is part of my life."
Children	Mention them early. Do not introduce a new person to them until you feel things are steady.

- ✕ Long stories about the ex on a first date.
- ✕ Comparing a new person to your ex or late partner.
- ✕ Sharing your address, your children's school, or your workplace early.

MEETING PEOPLE

WHERE TO MEET PEOPLE AFTER 35

Through friends	Tell friends you are open to being introduced. People like to help.
Activities	Classes, clubs, volunteering, sports. You meet people while doing something.
Community	Faith groups, neighbourhood events, alumni and work networks.
Apps and sites	Useful, but you need a safety routine (next chapter).

ONE GOAL FOR THE MONTH

Go to one place where you will see the same faces more than once.

APPS AND SAFETY

USING DATING APPS SAFELY

US survey data (Pew, 2023, all ages) found women were more likely than men to feel they got too many messages and to report unwanted contact. So a routine helps.

- [ ] Use a first name only. Keep your surname, address, workplace and children's details private.
- [ ] Keep chatting inside the app until you trust the person.
- [ ] Do a short video call before you meet.
- [ ] Reverse-search a photo if something feels off.
- [ ] Never send money, gift cards or crypto, or sensitive photos.
- [ ] Block and report anyone who ignores a no.

YOU DO NOT HAVE TO REPLY TO EVERYONE

Reply to people whose messages are warm and specific. Ignoring a message is allowed. Blocking is allowed.

PROFILE

PHOTOS AND BIO BASICS

Photos	4 to 6 recent ones. A clear smile in soft light, one full-length, one doing something you love.
Bio	2 to 4 lines. Something specific, something you love, and a question or an easy hook.
Honesty	Real age and a recent photo. Surprises on the first date help nobody.
Privacy	Avoid photos in front of your home, your children's school or your workplace.

WANT MORE?

The Profile Fixer for Women (35+) has templates, a photo audit and a rewrite worksheet.

MESSAGES

THE FIRST MESSAGE, AND REPLYING

Anyone can send the first message. If you do, keep it short and easy to answer. If you receive one, you decide.

HER

Hi Tom, you mention you cook. What is the dish you are proudest of?

HIM

A slow-cooked lamb. It takes all day. What do you cook?

HER

Soups, mostly. Things that look after themselves.

FOR EXAMPLES ONLY

Made-up names and lines that show a pattern. Use your own words.

A QUICK FILTER FOR REPLYING

- Is the message specific to me, or copy-paste?
- Does it ask a question I want to answer?
- Does it respect my pace and my no?

KEEP IT GOING

KEEP THE CONVERSATION GOING

Ask, then follow up	"What is the best part of your week?" then "What made that good?"
Share a little back	One question, one share. It keeps it from feeling like an interview.
Ask about what matters	"What are you hoping to find?" "How do you like to deal with disagreement?"
Say your pace	"I would like to go slowly" is a complete sentence.

MORE QUESTIONS

The Conversation Starters After 35 guide has cards for him, for her and for anyone.

FIRST DATE

YOUR FIRST-DATE SAFETY PLAN

- [ ] Meet in a public place, in daylight or early evening.
- [ ] Make your own way there and back.
- [ ] Tell a friend where you are going, who with, and when you will text them.
- [ ] Share your live location with that friend.
- [ ] Keep your phone charged and your drink and bag with you.
- [ ] Leave if you feel uneasy. You do not owe anyone an explanation.

ON PAYING

Customs vary. In all three countries a kind way to handle it is to offer to split, or say "next one is mine", and accept a no kindly.

AFTER THE DATE

Wait a day before you decide how it went. Many people leave a conversation thinking it went worse than the other person felt (the "liking gap"), though this was found in studies of strangers and students, not in daters over 35.

If you liked it	Send a short message: "I enjoyed meeting you. Would you like to do it again?"
If you are unsure	"Thank you for tonight. I would like some time to think." That is allowed.
If you did not	"It was nice to meet you. I do not think we are a match. I wish you well."

DATE DEBRIEF

BOUNDARIES

SAYING NO, CLEARLY AND KINDLY

Saying no is a skill. It does not need a long reason.

To a second date	"Thank you, but I do not feel a match."
To pressure	"I am not comfortable with that. Please stop."
To fast intimacy	"I would like to go slowly."
To contact after a no	Do not reply, and block. Keep the messages as a record.

YOU DO NOT NEED TO BE POLITE TWICE

If someone keeps contacting you after a clear no, you can block, report, and tell a friend.

HEALTHY OR NOT

IS THIS RELATIONSHIP HEALTHY?

SIGNS IT IS HEALTHY

- You feel calmer, not more anxious, after you see them.
- They respect "no" and "not yet".
- They are honest, including about awkward things.
- You still see friends and keep your routines.

SIGNS TO TAKE SERIOUSLY

- They control who you see, what you wear, or your money.
- They check your phone or track your location.
- They put you down or lose their temper, then say it was your fault.
- They isolate you from friends or family.
- You feel afraid of them.

IF YOU ARE FRIGHTENED

You can get confidential help. See "Where to get help" near the end for numbers in the USA, Canada and the UK.

YOUR PLAN

YOUR 30-DAY STARTER PLAN

- [ ] Week 1: Read the guide. Call one friend. Write your 30-second story.
- [ ] Week 2: Choose photos and write your bio. Join one activity.
- [ ] Week 3: Send or answer a few messages using the filter. Do one video call.
- [ ] Week 4: Meet someone for a safe, short coffee. Debrief and rest.

REMEMBER

One small step each week is enough. You can stop at any time.

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SUPPORT FOR DIVORCE, GRIEF AND RELATIONSHIPS

Starting again is easier with people around you. These services are for the stage before dating, or alongside it.

USA and Canada	**DivorceCare** (divorcecare.org) and **GriefShare** (griefshare.org) run local group programmes, often in churches. Fees and style vary. Some are faith-based.
UK	**Relate** (relate.org.uk) offers relationship counselling. Local centres set their own fees. **Cruse Bereavement Support:** 0808 808 1677.

A NOTE ON COUNSELLING

A licensed counsellor or therapist can help in ways a guide cannot. In the UK you can ask your GP or look for a BACP-registered counsellor. In the USA and Canada, ask your doctor or search a licensed-professional directory in your state or province.

CHECK FIRST

Numbers and hours change. If one fails, search the service's official website.

USA · CANADA · UK

DATING CUSTOMS: WHAT IS NORMAL WHERE YOU LIVE

Customs vary by city, age and background. Surveys on them are small and often company-run, and I found none on first dates for over-35s, so treat this as common practice and be kind.

Who pays	Surveys disagree. In US polls, answers were split between "the man", "whoever asked" and "split it". A UK survey found "split evenly" the most common answer. The safe move in all three countries: offer to split, or say "this one is on me, next one is yours", and accept a no kindly.
What to call it	In the USA and Canada people say "date" fairly early. In the UK, "meeting up" or "going for a drink" is common before anyone says "date". Match the other person's word.
Where to meet	A public place, in daylight, that you chose or know. Tell a friend where you are going and when you will message them. This is general safety advice, not a rule of any one country.
Apps	Pew (USA, 2022) found Tinder, Match and Bumble the most used among online daters. UK figures (Ofcom, 2024) show Tinder, Hinge and Bumble with the largest reach, and that Plenty of Fish and Badoo skew towards ages 35 to 54. No reliable ranking for Canada was found. Pick the app where people your age actually are.

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WHERE TO GET HELP

IF YOU FEEL HOPELESS OR UNSAFE

USA	**988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline.** Call or text 988, or chat at 988lifeline.org/chat. Free, 24/7. Emergency: 911.
Canada	**9-8-8 Suicide Crisis Helpline.** Call or text 988, 24/7, in English and French. Info: 988.ca. Emergency: 911.
UK	**Samaritans:** 116 123 (free, 24/7). **Shout:** text SHOUT to 85258. **NHS 111** for urgent mental-health help (choose the mental-health option). Emergency: 999.

IF A PARTNER OR EX FRIGHTENS YOU

USA	**National Domestic Violence Hotline:** 1-800-799-7233, or text START to 88788. thehotline.org. Internet use can be monitored: use a safe device.
Canada	There is no single national line. Find your province at **canada.ca** (search "gender-based violence crisis lines") or look up shelters at **sheltersafe.ca**. Emergency: 911.
UK	**National Domestic Abuse Helpline:** 0808 2000 247 (free, 24/7). **Men's Advice Line:** 0808 801 0327 for men experiencing abuse. If you cannot speak on a 999 call, press 55.

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IF YOU THINK YOU ARE BEING SCAMMED

Stop contact. Do not send more money. Tell your bank or card company straight away, keep the messages and screenshots, and report it. Shame keeps scams going: you are not the first, and reporting helps.

USA	Report to the FTC at **reportfraud.ftc.gov** and to the FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center at **ic3.gov**. If you sent money, tell your bank or card company straight away.
Canada	Report to the **Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre: 1-888-495-8501**, or online at antifraudcentre-centreantifraude.ca. If you lost money, also contact your local police and your bank.
UK	Report to **Report Fraud: reportfraud.police.uk, 0300 123 2040** (England, Wales and Northern Ireland; in Scotland call Police Scotland on 101). It replaced Action Fraud in December 2025. To reach your own bank's fraud team, **dial 159**.

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BE CALM.

BE CURIOUS.

BE REAL.

— Dorian Wolfe